

An Autistic Child in Your After-School / Childcare Setting

For childminders, after-school-club staff & support workers — caring for an autistic primary-school child (roughly ages 6–11).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a child's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." After a day of holding it together at school, an autistic child often arrives at your setting **running on empty** — and the crash happens with you. Your setting can be the recovery space they desperately need, *if* it's predictable, low-demand and sensory-kind. Resistance at tidy-up or snack-time is **inertia** (changing track costs energy), not defiance; a sudden change in behaviour usually means unmet need.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Meltdown or shutdown the moment they arrive	The school-day mask has dropped — a sign of trust and exhaustion
Won't start, stop or switch activities	Autistic inertia — changing track costs real energy
Won't eat, drink, or use the toilet when absorbed	Things outside the tunnel don't register
Distressed by noise, lights, crowding	Sensory overload after a long day
Clings to one object, routine or interest	These are regulation and safety anchors

Try this

- **Make arrival a decompression** — a calm, low-demand welcome; don't quiz them about the school day.
- **Keep a predictable routine**, staff and spaces; warn before every change; offer a quiet, low-light corner.
- **Protect the interest and downtime** — interest-led, side-by-side play is regulation and recovery.
- **Gentle, specific reminders** for food, drink and toilet; build in rest, not more demands.
- **Have a calm meltdown/shutdown plan**: reduce input, ensure safety, give time, don't restrain or reason in the moment.
- **Share a two-way note with home and school** — consistency across all three prevents many hard days.

Avoid this

- Piling on activities, group games or "how was school?" on an already depleted child.
- Surprise changes, forced group work, or stopping stimming.
- Reading a crash as naughtiness, or a quiet spell as "they're fine."

When to get more support

Watch for **autistic burnout / “regression”** — a drop in skills usually means *overwhelm*; respond by **reducing demands and restoring rest and interests**. Investigate **pain or overload first** for any new distress. Liaise with parents and the school SENCO/SEND lead.

If the child is a girl

Girls camouflage heavily and may arrive having held it together all day; the quiet, compliant child may be on the edge of shutdown. Watch for withdrawal and check in gently.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 1), the **Family guide** (Part 3) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool**. Fit it to the individual child.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Reframing Autism (2023); Kelly Mahler (2024, interoception); Edgar (2024, regression/burnout). Full citations are in the source drafts.